

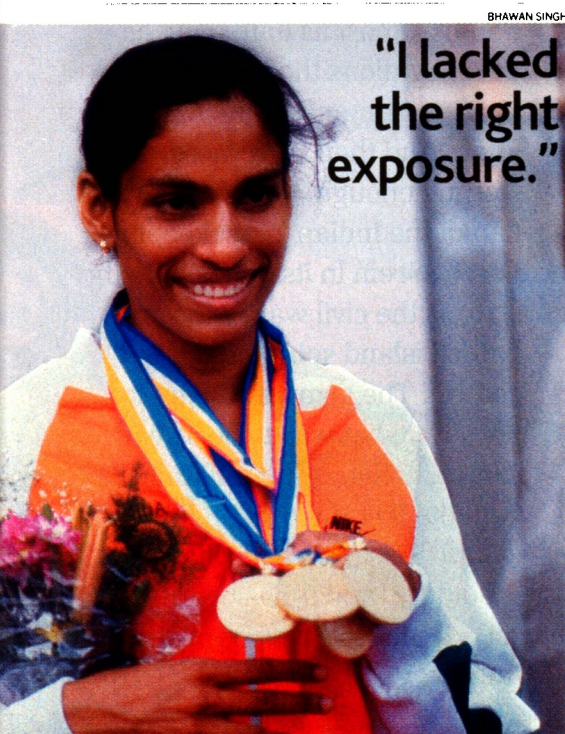
"I HAVE NO INDIAN PAPERS."

Subhas Ghising

"My identification is Gorkhaland," claimed Subhas Ghising, but he made headlines across India when he launched his 11-point separatist agenda in Darjeeling on April 13. What followed was a sate of crippling *bandhs*, escalating violence against tea-planters and skirmishes between CPI(M) workers and the local police which brought the situation to a peak in the second half of the year. Eventually, Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi was able to placate Ghising by allowing him an autonomous hill council rather than a state for Nepali speakers. The Centre, in effect, helped him stake the claim of being the spokesman of the 15 lakh Gorkhas in and around Darjeeling. And he found himself in the position of being able to play off the Centre against West Bengal in a situation where the two needed maximum cooperation.



SAIBAL DAS



BHAWAN SINGH

"I lacked the right exposure."

For the Olympics, she may have lacked the right exposure but at the Asian Games, P.T. Usha thundered through Seoul, winning four gold and one silver medal, creating new Games records in every event she participated in.

THE GOLDEN PEN

Vikram Seth rocked the literary world with his book-in-verse, *The Golden Gate*. Styled along the rhyming tetrameter sonnets of Charles Johnston's 1977 translation of Alexander Pushkin's *Eugene Onegin*, a book he found in a Stanford second-hand bookstore, it changed the direction of his career, from academic to literary work. And gave India a new wordstar.



- Swedish Prime Minister Olof Palme, 59, was assassinated in Stockholm where he was leaving a cinema hall with his wife, Lisbet.
- Space shuttle *Challenger* disintegrated 73 seconds after the launch, killing its crew of six astronauts and schoolteacher Christa McAuliffe.
- In the world's worst nuclear disaster (below), one of the reactors at the Chernobyl nuclear plant in Ukraine exploded, killing 31. Thousands more died from cancer due to exposure to radiation later.



AP

1 lakh

was the number of Maruti cars produced in 1986. The company, a brainchild of Sanjay Gandhi that had gone into liquidation in 1977, completed its turnaround to profitability when Suzuki came on board in 1980.